PADHAKU
Exploring Society: India and Beyond · Class 6 Social Science



CHAPTER 7

India’s Cultural Roots

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Big Questions	3 Q
Let’s Explore · Vedic society	1 Q
Think About It · Stories from the Upaniṣhads	1 Q
Let’s Explore · Buddhism	2 Q
Let’s Explore · Jainism	1 Q
Questions, activities and projects	7 Q
True or false	7 Q
Class activity	1 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

Independent study aid by Beginers Point. Not an official NCERT publication.

The Big Questions

1 What are the Vedas? What is their message?

✔ ANSWER

The Vedas are the **most ancient texts of India** (and among the oldest in the world). The word "Veda" comes from Sanskrit *vid*, meaning 'knowledge'.

There are four Vedas: **Ṛig Veda, Yajur Veda, Sāma Veda and Atharva Veda**. They are thousands of hymns (prayers as poems and songs), composed by rishis and rishikas and passed on orally.

Their message:

- Truth and order (ṛitam) in human life and the cosmos.
- The supreme reality is one, though sages give it many names (*ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti*).
- Unity among people: "Come together, speak together... united be your purpose, united your heart."

2 What new schools of thought emerged in India in the 1st millennium BCE? What are their core principles?

✔ ANSWER

- **Vedanta** (from the Upaniṣhads): everything is one divine essence, **brahman**; the **ātman** (Self) in every being is one with brahman; ideas of rebirth and karma.
- **Yoga**: methods to realise brahman in one's consciousness.
- **Buddhism**: ignorance (avidyā) and attachment cause suffering; **ahimsa** (non-hurting), inner discipline.
- **Jainism**: **ahimsa**, **anekāntavāda** (truth has many aspects) and **aparigraha** (non-possession); all creatures are interconnected.
- **Chārvāka** (Lokāyata): only the material world exists; it did not last.

Common ideas: dharma, karma, rebirth, and the search for an end to suffering and ignorance.

3 What is the contribution of folk and tribal traditions to Indian culture?

✔ ANSWER

- They are **oral traditions** passed on through everyday practice, and they count among India's cultural roots.
- Deities, ideas, legends and rituals were exchanged both ways with Hinduism, e.g. **Jagannath** of Puri was originally a tribal deity; many forms of the mother-goddess also.

- They treat nature (mountains, rivers, trees, animals) as **sacred**, and many have a supreme deity (Donyipolo, Singbonga).
- The result is **mutual enrichment** of Indian culture.

⭐ Let's Explore · Vedic society

1 **Do you know the term for a society where people select their leaders? How do you think people can benefit from such a situation? What could happen if they live under leaders that they did not choose? Write your thoughts in 100–150 words.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A society where people select their leaders is called a **democracy**.

In a democracy, people choose leaders who understand their needs. If leaders do not work well, people can replace them in the next election. People can speak freely, take part in decisions and feel that the government belongs to them. This makes leaders responsible and careful. Even the Vedic people had assemblies called *sabhā* and *samiti* where people gathered together.

If people live under leaders they did not choose, the leaders may not care about their problems. They may make rules only for their own benefit, and people may not be able to complain or change them. This can lead to unfair treatment, fear and loss of freedom. So choosing our own leaders helps everyone live with dignity and fairness.

🤔 Think About It · Stories from the Upaniṣhads

1 **Have you heard or read any other story that conveyed an important message? What values did it teach you?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, the Panchatantra story **"The Thirsty Crow"**: a crow found a pot with little water, dropped pebbles into it until the water rose, and drank.

Values: **patience, hard work and clever thinking** — never give up when facing a problem.

⭐ Let's Explore · Buddhism

1 **Discuss the way the Buddha is depicted in the stone panel (some 1,800 years old) showing the Buddha teaching.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The Buddha is shown **seated calmly in the centre**, bigger than others, with a peaceful face and a halo behind his head. People around him listen with respect, showing that he is a great teacher spreading his message (check the picture in your book).

2 **Can you name some states of India or some other countries where Buddhism is a major religion even today? Try to plot these on a world map.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- States of India: **Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Ladakh** (Union Territory), Maharashtra also has many Buddhists.
- Countries: **Sri Lanka, Bhutan, Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos, Japan, Mongolia, Vietnam**.

Mark these on a world map in class.

⭐ Let's Explore · Jainism

1 **Observe the panel (from a Jain temple in New Delhi). What is striking about it? What messages does it carry?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

It shows different creatures — humans and animals — together in peace. Its message is **ahimsa** (do not harm any living being) and that all creatures are **interconnected** and depend on each other (check the picture in your book).

? Questions, activities and projects

1 **If you were Nachiketa, what questions would you like to ask Yama? Write them down in 100–150 words.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- What happens to a person after death?
- What is the ātman, and why is it never born and never dies?
- How can a person live a good life and be free from sorrow?
- Why do good people also suffer sometimes?
- What is the difference between what is pleasant and what is truly good?
- How does karma decide our future?
- Can a person be free from the cycle of birth and death? How?
- Why are people afraid of death, and how can we lose this fear?
- What is the greatest wealth a person can have?

I would ask these to understand the truth about life, just as Nachiketa did with patience and courage.

2 **Explain a few central ideas of Buddhism. Briefly comment upon them.**

✔ ANSWER

- **Cause of suffering:** ignorance (avidyā) and attachment cause human suffering; removing them ends suffering. *Comment:* when we are too attached to things, losing them makes us unhappy.
- **Ahimsa:** non-hurting or non-injuring any being. *Comment:* it teaches kindness to all.
- **Inner discipline:** purity comes from truth and dharma within, not from bathing in rivers; conquering oneself is greater than conquering a thousand men. *Comment:* controlling our anger and greed is the real victory.
- **Sangha:** a community of monks and nuns who practise and spread the teachings.

3 **Discuss in class the quotation of the Buddha which begins with "Not by water is one made pure..."**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Meaning: Bathing in sacred rivers only cleans the body. A person becomes truly pure only when **truth and dharma (right conduct) live in his heart**.

The second part says that **controlling oneself** (one's anger, greed, bad habits) is greater than defeating a thousand men in battle a thousand times. Real strength is self-control.

4 **Explain a few central ideas of Jainism. Briefly comment upon them.**

✔ ANSWER

- **Ahimsa:** no living, breathing creature should be killed, hurt, abused or driven away. *Comment:* it includes not even having ill thoughts towards anyone.
- **Anekāntavāda:** 'not just one' view — truth has many aspects and no single statement can describe it fully. *Comment:* it teaches us to respect other people's views.
- **Aparigraha:** non-possession — keep only what is truly necessary. *Comment:* it reduces greed and waste.
- **Interconnectedness:** all creatures, from humans to tiny organisms, depend on each other; science also confirms this.

5 **Consider and discuss in class André Béteille's thought.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Béteille says that the thousands of castes and tribes of India have **influenced each other's beliefs and practices** since before history began.

Tribal religions have been influenced by Hinduism, and **Hinduism has also been influenced by tribal religions** throughout its growth (e.g. Jagannath was originally a tribal deity; tribes have their own Rāmāyaṇa and Mahābhārata).

So this give-and-take has led to **mutual enrichment** of Indian culture.

6 **Make a list of popular gods and goddesses in your region and the festivals they are associated with.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample (North India):

God / Goddess	Festival
Rama	Dussehra, Diwali, Ram Navami
Krishna	Janmashtami, Holi
Durga	Navratri, Durga Puja
Shiva	Mahashivratri
Ganesha	Ganesh Chaturthi
Lakshmi	Diwali

Surya (Sun)	Chhath Puja, Makar Sankranti

Make your own list for your region.

7 **As a class activity, list two or three tribal groups from your region or State. Document some of their art and belief systems.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample:

- **Santhal** (Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha): worship **Singbonga**, the supreme deity; dances and music with drums; festival Sohrai.
- **Toda** (Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu): regard over thirty mountain peaks as homes of gods; do not point at them with a finger; fine embroidery.
- **Warli** (Maharashtra): famous **Warli paintings** of daily life with white figures; worship nature.

Find the tribes of your own State and note their art and beliefs.

⭐ True or false

1 **The Vedic hymns were written on palm-leaf manuscripts.**

✔ **ANSWER**

False. They were recited and passed on **orally**, not written.

2 **The Vedas are India’s oldest texts.**

✔ ANSWER

True. They are the most ancient texts of India.

3 **The Vedic statement *ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti* reflects a belief in the unity of cosmic powers.**

✔ ANSWER

True. It means the supreme reality is one, but sages give it many names.

4 **Buddhism is older than the Vedas.**

✔ ANSWER

False. The Vedas are much older; Buddhism began about 2,500 years ago.

5 **Jainism emerged as a branch of Buddhism.**

✔ ANSWER

False. Jainism is a separate school; its roots are said to be even more ancient.

6 **Both Buddhism and Jainism advocated for peaceful coexistence and the avoidance of harm to all living beings.**

✔ ANSWER

True. Both teach ahimsa.

7 **Tribal belief systems are limited to belief in spirits and minor deities.**

✔ ANSWER

False. Many tribes have a supreme being, e.g. Donyipolo, Singbonga.

🧪 Class activity

1 **Stage a small play with Yama, god of death, surrounded by several Nachiketas asking him questions about life.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample script:

Nachiketa 1: O Yama, what happens after the body dies?

Yama: The ātman, the Self, lives in all creatures. It is neither born nor does it die.

Nachiketa 2: Then why do people fear death?

Yama: Because they do not know the Self and are attached to the body and things.

Nachiketa 3: How should we live?

Yama: Choose what is good, not just what is pleasant. Speak the truth and do right actions.

All Nachiketas: Thank you, Yama! We will seek true knowledge.

🎉 **Chapter 7 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**